

NOTHING SAYS CONFIDENCE LIKE PREVENTABLE INJURY

Protection in snow sports is often framed as a matter of safety, yet the decision to wear it is largely social. Within ski and snowboard culture, clothing and equipment communicate your level of competence, experience and belonging. Specifically, protective gear is frequently associated with inexperience, caution, or “trying too hard”, while effortlessness and risk-taking are seen as signs of mastery. These unwritten rules are further shaped by gendered expectations around appearance, performance and self-presentation. As a result, efforts to improve safety generally have to operate in conflict with or in spite of this phenomenon.

Nothing Says Confidence Like Preventable Injury incorporates cultural research into protection culture with the design of a technical ski outfit. Developed in collaboration with the Dutch back-protector company Spines, the ski jacket and pants integrate back, hip & tailbone protection directly into the garment. Rather than concealing these elements, the design makes them visible and part of the aesthetic language of the outfit. With the prototype and accompanying visual campaign, the work explores how protection can become desirable, visible and socially accepted, rather than something hidden or associated with inexperience.

The work addresses skiers and snowboarders, particularly younger generations who actively shape trends and attitudes within snow sports, and investigates how design can influence behaviour without relying on instruction, fear, or regulation.